Towards the north, running from west to east, the watershed is all too obvious as it runs from the Yamunotri group of peaks to Gangotri and then onto the Nanda Devi group. Though the region was invaded and captured by the rampaging Gorkhas towards the end of the eighteenth century—their kingdom extending up to Kangra in the Punjab—this is perhaps the least disputed part of the present day Indo-Chinese boundary.

Ironically, the one region in the Himalayan belt where the border was perhaps the most volatile and the boundary kept shifting during the last two hundred years is today the only completely settled international boundary—the Tibet (China)-Nepal border. Ever since 1788 when the Nepalese first invaded Tibet in modern times, territorial expansion made the watershed of the Great Himalayan Range redundant. Nevertheless, after Chinese intervention and the defeat of Nepal in the 1792 war with Tibet, as per the Treaty of Betrawati, the Himalayan watershed more or less was considered to be the border. However, in the absence of any scientific survey, certain pasturelands remained under dispute.

After invading and annexing Tibet, China diligently worked towards settling and demarcating the China-Nepal border. The boundary agreement was then signed on 5 October 1961 by the king of Nepal and Mao after which the actual boundary line was demarcated physically. During the joint boundary demarcation, there were claims and counter-claims about thirty-two points. These were quickly settled by the Chinese who were also treating the settlement of the boundary with Nepal and Myanmar around that time as a means to show the rest of the world just how reasonable they were. Regarding the question of Mount Everest, the dispute was settled when the visiting prime minister, Chou En-lai, made a statement in Kathmandu that ‘Mount Everest belongs to Nepal’.

Hidden from the rest of the world, the days of peaceful isolation of the Lepcha, the original inhabitants of the Teesta River Valley, were numbered, as the door into ‘Mayelyang’ (Sikkim) was forced open by the Bhutia people who hitherto lived above the clouds to the north. In the mid-seventeenth century, the situation was to change dramatically with the arrival of Tibetan lamas who instituted a monarchy as the protector of the faith. Buddhism and Lamaism, having originated in India prior to flourishing in Tibet, had returned to India. The wheel had turned a full circle. With the coronation of the first Chogyal, Sikkim entered what can best be described as its medieval period.